“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 3

The Reasons for Śrī Caitanya's Advent

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu. By the power of taking shelter at His feet, even an ignorant person gathers the precious jewels of conclusive truth from a multitude of mines.

2 All glory, all glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaita-candra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 I have explained the meaning of the third verse. Now, O devotees, hear the meaning of the fourth.

4 “Out of mercy He has descended in the age of Kali to bestow what had not been given for a long time: the treasure of devotion to Himself, rich in the most exalted and radiant *rasa* of divine love. May that Lord Hari, the son of Śacī, resplendent with a mass of radiance more beautiful than gold, ever shine in the cave of your heart.” (Vidagdha-mādhava 1.2)

5 Kṛṣṇa, the son of the king of Vraja, is the Supreme Lord in His fullness. Together with His Vraja He enjoys eternal pastimes in Goloka.

6 Once in a day of Brahmā He descends and displays these pastimes openly in this world.

7 There are four ages: Satya, Tretā, Dvāpara and Kali. Together these four are counted as one divine age (*divya-yuga*).

8 Seventy-one such cycles make one *manvantara*, the reign of a Manu, and a day of Brahmā holds fourteen manvantaras.

9 The present manvantara, the seventh, is called Vaivasvata. When twenty-seven of its cycles of four ages have passed,

10 at the end of the Dvāpara age of the twenty-eighth cycle, Kṛṣṇa appears in this world together with His Vraja.

11 Servitude, friendship, parental love and amorous love are the four *rasas*. Kṛṣṇa is under the sway of all the devotees who love Him in these four moods.

12 With His servants, His friends, His father and mother and His beloveds, Kṛṣṇa sports in Vraja, absorbed in love.

13 When He has sported to His heart's content, Kṛṣṇa disappears. Then He reflects within Himself:

14 “For a long time I have not given the gift of loving devotion (*prema-bhakti*). Without devotion the world cannot truly stand.

15 Everywhere in the world people worship Me by the rules of scripture (*vidhi-bhakti*). But devotion by rules has no power to attain the mood of Vraja.

16 The whole world is tinged with awareness of My majesty, and love weakened by awe of My majesty does not please Me.

17 Those who worship by the rules, aware of My majesty, attain the four kinds of liberation and go to Vaikuṇṭha:

18 *sārṣṭi*, opulence equal to Mine; *sārūpya*, a form like Mine; *sāmīpya*, nearness to Me; and *sālokya*, residence in My world. The devotee never accepts *sāyujya*, merging, in which one becomes one with Brahman.

19 I shall establish the religion of the age, the congregational chanting of the Holy Name (*nāma-saṅkīrtana*). Giving devotion in the four moods, I shall make the whole world dance.

20 I Myself shall take the mood of a devotee, and by practising devotion Myself I shall teach it to everyone.

21 Unless one practises religion oneself, one cannot teach it. This conclusion is sung in the Gītā and the Bhāgavatam:

22 “Whenever religion declines and irreligion rises, O descendant of Bharata, I manifest Myself.” (Bhagavad-gītā 4.7)

23 “To deliver the saintly, to destroy the wicked and to establish religion, I appear age after age.” (Bhagavad-gītā 4.8)

24 “If I did not perform action, these worlds would perish. I would cause confusion among the social orders and ruin all these people.” (Bhagavad-gītā 3.24)

25 “Whatever a great man does, others do the same. Whatever standard he sets, the world follows.” (Bhagavad-gītā 3.21)

26 The religion of each age is established by My partial manifestations, but no one except Me can give the love of Vraja.

27 “Let the lotus-naveled Lord have many avatāras, all of them auspicious in every way. But who other than Kṛṣṇa gives love even to the creepers?” (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta 1.5.37)

28 Therefore I shall descend to earth with My own devotees as My companions and enjoy many kinds of pastimes.”

29 Thinking in this way, Kṛṣṇa Himself descended in Nadia in the first period (*sandhyā*) of the age of Kali.

30 Thus the lion Caitanya descended in Navadvīpa. He had the neck of a lion, the strength of a lion and the roar of a lion.

31 May that lion take His seat in the cave of the heart of every soul. His roar destroys the elephant of sin.

32 In His early pastimes His name was Viśvambhara, for He filled the world with the *rasa* of devotion and sustained all living beings.

33 The verbal root *ḍubhṛñ* means “to nourish” and “to sustain.” By giving love He nourished and sustained the three worlds.

34 In His later pastimes He bears the name Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya. By making Śrī Kṛṣṇa known, He blessed the whole universe.

35 Knowing Him to be the avatāra for the age, the great sage Garga declared it at Kṛṣṇa's name-giving ceremony:

36 “Your son appears in every age, accepting a body. He has had three colors: white, red and yellow. Now He has come dark.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.8.13)

37 The husband of Śrī assumes these three lusters, white, red and yellow, in the Satya, Tretā and Kali ages.

38 Now, in the Dvāpara age, He has become dark. This is the essence of the scriptures, the Āgamas and the Purāṇas.

39 “In the Dvāpara age the Lord appears dark, clad in yellow, bearing His own weapons and marked with the Śrīvatsa and other signs.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.5.27)

40 In the age of Kali the religion of the age is spreading the Holy Name. For this purpose the Lord has descended as Caitanya, yellow in color.

41 His luster is like molten gold and His body is tall and mighty. His deep voice surpasses the thunder of fresh rain clouds.

42 One whose height and the span of whose arms both measure four of his own cubits is known as a *mahā-puruṣa*, a great personality.

43 Such a person is called *nyagrodha-parimaṇḍala*, “proportioned like a banyan tree.” Caitanya, the abode of all virtues, has such a body.

44 His arms reach down to His knees and His eyes are like lotuses. His nose is finer than the sesame flower, and His face is like the moon.

45 He is peaceful and self-controlled, wholly and steadfastly given to devotion to Kṛṣṇa. He is affectionate to His devotees, gentle by nature and equal to all living beings.

46 When He dances in the congregational chanting of Kṛṣṇa's names, He wears armlets and bracelets of sandalwood and is adorned with sandal paste.

47 Taking all these qualities into account, the sage Vaiśampāyana listed His names in the Thousand Names of Viṣṇu (*Viṣṇu-sahasra-nāma*).

48 Caitanya's pastimes have two parts, the early and the later, and in each He bears four special names.

49 “His complexion is golden and His body is like gold. His limbs are beautiful, and He wears armlets of sandalwood. He accepts the renounced order (*sannyāsa*). He is equipoised and peaceful, the supreme abode of steadfastness and peace.” (Viṣṇu-sahasra-nāma, Mahābhārata)

50 The Bhāgavatam says clearly, again and again, that in the age of Kali the congregational chanting of Kṛṣṇa's name is the essence of all religion.

51 “Intelligent people worship, by sacrifices consisting chiefly of congregational chanting, the Lord who always utters the name ‘Kṛṣṇa’ (*kṛṣṇa-varṇam*) and whose luster is not dark. He is accompanied by His limbs, His sub-limbs, His weapons and His associates.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.5.32)

52 Hear, brothers, all this glory of Caitanya. This verse tells the very limit of His glory.

53 The two syllables “Kṛṣ-ṇa” are always in His mouth; or else, He describes Kṛṣṇa in His own joy.

54 These are the two established meanings of the word *kṛṣṇa-varṇa*. Nothing but Kṛṣṇa ever comes to His lips.

55 If anyone should call Him dark in color, the next epithet rules this out.

56 By the luster of His body He is not dark, and “not dark” means yellow.

57 “In the age of Kali the wise openly worship Kṛṣṇa, whose body is not dark because of its abundant luster, with sacrificial rites that consist of loud chanting of His names. They declare Him the object of worship of all who live in the renounced order. May that Lord, who has appeared in the form of Caitanya, be abundantly merciful to us.” (Stava-mālā, Second Caitanyāṣṭaka 1)

58 His luster of molten gold is plain to see, and its radiance dispels the darkness of ignorance.

59 To destroy the darkness of the souls' sins, He bears various weapons: His limbs (*aṅga*), His sub-limbs (*upāṅga*) and the Holy Name.

60 Any action opposed to devotion, whether pious or impious, is called *kalmaṣa*, sin. That is the great darkness.

61 Raising His arms and calling “Hari!”, He looks on all with eyes full of love. He destroys their sins and floods them with love.

62 “His smiling glance takes away all the sorrow of the world, and the mere beginning of His words makes good fortune blossom in abundance. What flood of love does the touch of His feet not bring forth? May that Lord, who has appeared in the form of Caitanya, be abundantly merciful to us.” (Stava-mālā, Second Caitanyāṣṭaka 8)

63 Whoever sees His beautiful body and His beautiful face is freed from sin and receives the treasure of love.

64 In His other avatāras the Lord came with soldiers and weapons, but the army of Kṛṣṇa as Caitanya is His limbs and sub-limbs.

65 “The gods headed by Śiva and Brahmā, who took human bodies and bore love for Him, always worship Him. To His own devotees He teaches

the pure way of worshipping Him. Will that beautiful Caitanya ever again come within the range of my eyes?" (Stava-mālā, First Caitanyāṣṭaka 1)

66 His limbs and sub-limbs are the weapons that accomplish His work. Now hear attentively another meaning of the word *aṅga*.

67 According to the evidence of scripture, the word *aṅga* means a plenary portion (*aṁśa*), and *upāṅga* is explained as a part of that portion.

68 "O Lord, are You not Nārāyaṇa? You are the Self of all embodied beings and the witness of all the worlds. The one called Nārāyaṇa because His resting place is the water born of Nara is Your portion. And that portion too is real; it is not Your māyā." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.14.14)

69 The Nārāyaṇa who lies on the water and dwells within all is Your portion. You are the original Nārāyaṇa.

70 Here the word *aṅga* means a portion, and that portion too is real. It is not a product of māyā; it is wholly spiritual and full of bliss.

71 Advaita and Nityānanda are the two limbs (*aṅga*) of Caitanya, and I call the parts of these limbs His sub-limbs (*upāṅga*).

72 His limbs and sub-limbs are sharp weapons that are always with the Lord, and all these weapons serve to crush the unbelievers (*pāṣaṇḍa*).

73 Lord Nityānanda is Haladhara Himself, the bearer of the plow, and Advaita Ācārya is the Lord Himself.

74 Taking with them the army of associates headed by Śrīvāsa, these two generals go about performing *kīrtana*.

75 Nityānanda Rāya is vowed to crush the unbelievers, and at the roar of Advaita Ācārya sin and the unbelievers flee.

76 Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya is the founder of saṅkīrtana. Whoever worships Him by the sacrifice of saṅkīrtana is truly fortunate.

77 Such a person is truly intelligent, while the rest of the world lacks good sense. Of all sacrifices, the sacrifice of chanting Kṛṣṇa's name is the essence.

78 Whoever says that ten million horse sacrifices equal a single name of Kṛṣṇa is an unbeliever, and Yama punishes him.

79 In the invocation of his book *Bhāgavata-sandarbha*, Śrī Jīva Gosvāmī has explained this verse:

80 “In the age of Kali, through saṅkīrtana and other practices, we have taken shelter of Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, who is Kṛṣṇa within and golden without, and who has displayed the splendor of His limbs and sub-limbs.” (Bhāgavata-sandarbha 1.2)

81 In the Upapurāṇas too we hear the words that Śrī Kṛṣṇa mercifully spoke to Vyāsa:

82 “O brāhmaṇa, sometimes I Myself accept the renounced order (*sannyāsa*) and lead the people of Kali, stricken by sin, to accept devotion to Hari.”

83 The Bhāgavatam, the Mahābhārata, the Āgamas and the Purāṇas give clear evidence of Kṛṣṇa's descent as Caitanya.

84 And you can see with your own eyes His many manifest powers: His extraordinary deeds and His extraordinary signs of ecstasy (*anubhāva*).

85 Yet the nondevotees see all this and do not see it, just as the owl does not see the rays of the sun.

86 “Your character, form and deeds are supremely excellent, and Your strength and pure goodness, the mighty scriptures and the views of renowned godly knowers of the highest truth all make You known. Yet those of demonic nature can never understand You.” (Stotra-ratna 12)

87 Kṛṣṇa makes many efforts to hide Himself, yet His devotee knows Him.

88 “Your supreme nature transcends the three kinds of limits, and nothing can be equal to it or greater. Though You hide it by the power of Your own māyā, some, devoted to You alone, see it at all times.” (Stotra-ratna 13)

89 Those of demonic nature never know Kṛṣṇa, but Kṛṣṇa cannot hide from His devotees.

90 “In this world there are two kinds of created beings, the divine and the demonic. A devotee of Viṣṇu is called divine, and the demonic is his opposite.” (Padma Purāṇa)

91 Advaita Ācārya is the Lord's avatāra as a devotee, and His roar caused Kṛṣṇa to descend.

92 Whenever Kṛṣṇa descends on earth, He first sends His elders.

93 First He has all those He honors, His father, mother, guru and others, take birth on earth.

94 Mādhavendra Purī, Īśvara Purī, Śacī and Jagannātha Miśra appeared, and Advaita Ācārya appeared along with them.

95 When Advaita Ācārya appeared, He saw the whole world absorbed in worldly affairs, without a trace of devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

96 Some enjoyed the world through sin and some through piety, but no one had even a trace of devotion, which cures the disease of worldly existence.

97 Seeing the condition of the people, the compassionate Ācārya considered how they could be truly benefited.

98 "If Śrī Kṛṣṇa Himself descends, He will practise devotion Himself and preach it.

99 In the age of Kali there is no religion but the Holy Name. Yet how will Kṛṣṇa descend in the age of Kali?

100 I shall worship Kṛṣṇa with a pure heart and entreat Him constantly with humility.

101 If I bring Kṛṣṇa and spread *kīrtana*, only then will My name Advaita be fulfilled."

102 As He considered by what worship He could win Kṛṣṇa over, a verse came to His mind:

103 "Kṛṣṇa, who is affectionate to His devotees, sells Himself to them for merely a leaf of tulasī or a palmful of water." (Gautamīya-tantra)

104–105 The Ācārya pondered the meaning of this verse: "When someone offers Kṛṣṇa tulasī and water, Kṛṣṇa thinks how to repay His debt to that person: 'In My house there is no wealth equal to water and tulasī.'

106 So He repays the debt by selling Himself." Thinking in this way, the Ācārya began His worship.

107 Meditating on Kṛṣṇa's lotus feet, He constantly offered them tulasī buds (*mañjarī*) with Gaṅgā water.

108 With mighty roars He called out to Kṛṣṇa, and in this way He caused Kṛṣṇa to descend.

109 This is the main cause of Caitanya's descent: the Lord, the upholder of religion, descends by the desire of His devotee.

110 “O Lord, You are seen by the path of hearing, and You dwell in the lotus of the heart purified by *bhakti-yoga*. O widely glorified Lord, whatever form of Yours Your devotees contemplate, You manifest that very form to show them Your favor.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 3.9.11)

111 I tell the essence of this verse in brief: all of Kṛṣṇa's descents take place by the desire of His devotees.

112 Thus the meaning of the fourth verse has been firmly established: Gaura descended to reveal love (*prema*).

113 Ever hoping for the mercy of the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate *Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.